

FREE RESOURCE · LEADERSHIP & FACILITATION

# Leadership Styles Overview

A concise guide to 6 leadership styles — when to use each, their strengths and limitations, and self-assessment prompts to identify your own default pattern.

6 Styles

When to Use

Strengths & Limitations

Self-Assessment

6

styles

4

lenses per style

12

reflection prompts

3

score patterns

## HOW TO USE

No single style is "best" — the most effective leaders move deliberately between styles depending on the person and the situation, rather than defaulting to one regardless of context. Read through all six, then use the self-assessment prompts to identify which styles you reach for automatically, and which you may be under-using.

## The 6 Styles at a Glance

| Style                                                                                           | In One Line           |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------|
|  Visionary   | "Come with me."       |
|  Coaching    | "Try this."           |
|  Affiliative | "People come first."  |
|  Democratic  | "What do you think?"  |
|  Pacesetter  | "Do as I do, now."    |
|  Commanding  | "Do what I tell you." |

## A NOTE ON ORIGIN

This framework draws on the six leadership styles first popularised by psychologist Daniel Goleman, based on research into how different styles affect team climate and performance. It groups the styles into two broad families:

four styles that build long-term climate and engagement (Visionary, Coaching, Affiliative, Democratic) and two that can produce fast short-term results but carry higher risk if overused (Pacesetting, Commanding).

## The 6 Leadership Styles

Work through each style below. For each one, be honest about how often you actually use it — not how often you believe you should.

### LEADERSHIP STYLE

## Visionary

*"Come with me."*

The visionary leader sets a clear, compelling direction and gives people the freedom to work out how to get there. This style is built on painting a picture of where the organisation or team is heading and why it matters — then stepping back to let people innovate, experiment, and take ownership of the path.

### WHEN TO USE

New strategic direction is needed. A team has lost sight of purpose. Change requires people to see beyond the immediate task to the bigger picture.

### STRENGTHS

- Creates strong buy-in because people understand the 'why', not just the 'what'
- Gives room for individual initiative and creativity within a shared direction
- Particularly effective during periods of change or uncertainty

### LIMITATIONS

- Less effective with experts who already know more than the leader about the work itself
- Can feel vague or ungrounded if not paired with concrete near-term milestones
- Overuse can create a leader who is inspiring but disconnected from delivery detail

### SELF-ASSESSMENT PROMPTS

Think of the last time you set a direction for your team. Did people understand the destination, or only the next task?

How comfortable are you letting go of the 'how' once you have set the 'why'?

## LEADERSHIP STYLE

# Coaching

*"Try this."*

The coaching leader focuses on long-term development — connecting what a person is doing today to their broader career goals and capabilities. It involves regular one-to-one conversation, delegated stretch assignments, and a genuine investment in helping individuals grow, even when that growth is slower than simply doing the task yourself.

**WHEN TO USE**

Developing a capable team member for future responsibility. Building capability that will outlast a single project. A talented person is underperforming due to unclear growth path.

**STRENGTHS**

- Builds long-term capability and loyalty within a team
- Increases confidence and initiative in team members over time
- Strengthens the leader's own succession pipeline

**LIMITATIONS**

- Requires time and patience that not every situation allows
- Ineffective with people who resist feedback or lack motivation to grow
- Can be mistaken for micromanagement if development conversations become too frequent or directive

**SELF-ASSESSMENT PROMPTS**

**When did you last have a development-focused conversation with a team member that was not tied to a specific task or deadline?**

**Who on your team would most benefit from more of this style right now — and what is stopping you from giving it to them?**

## LEADERSHIP STYLE

## Affiliative

*"People come first."*

The affiliative leader prioritises emotional bonds and harmony within the team. It values praise, connection, and belonging — building the kind of trust that helps a team recover from conflict, loss, or a difficult period, and that makes people feel safe enough to take risks together.

**WHEN TO USE**

A team is recovering from conflict, restructuring, or a difficult period. Trust needs rebuilding. Morale is low and people need to feel valued before they can perform.

**STRENGTHS**

- Builds strong team cohesion and psychological safety
- Effective at repairing relationships and rebuilding trust after disruption
- Increases loyalty and reduces attrition in high-pressure environments

**LIMITATIONS**

- Used alone, can allow poor performance to go unaddressed for the sake of harmony
- May avoid necessary but difficult conversations
- Can create a culture where feedback feels risky because conflict is avoided rather than resolved

**SELF-ASSESSMENT PROMPTS**

**Think about a recent piece of underperformance on your team. Did concern for harmony delay the conversation that needed to happen?**

**How do your team members know that you value them as people, separate from their output?**

## LEADERSHIP STYLE

## Democratic

*"What do you think?"*

The democratic leader builds consensus through participation — inviting input, listening genuinely, and using the collective intelligence of the team to shape decisions. It works by valuing people's contributions enough to let them shape outcomes, not just execute them.

**WHEN TO USE**

Buy-in matters as much as the decision itself. The leader lacks full information and needs the team's expertise. Time allows for genuine consultation rather than a fast, unilateral call.

**STRENGTHS**

- Produces higher-quality decisions by drawing on diverse expertise
- Builds strong ownership because people helped shape the outcome
- Surfaces risks and blind spots the leader alone would have missed

**LIMITATIONS**

- Slow — unsuitable for crises or time-critical decisions
- Can produce indecision if consensus never fully forms
- Risks frustrating experienced team members if consultation becomes performative rather than genuine

**SELF-ASSESSMENT PROMPTS**

**Think of a recent decision you made alone that affected your team directly. What would have changed had you asked for their input first?**

**Do you know the difference, in practice, between consulting your team and simply announcing a decision you have already made?**

## LEADERSHIP STYLE

## Pacesetting

*"Do as I do, now."*

The pacesetting leader sets a high performance bar and models it personally — expecting the same standard and speed from everyone else. It relies on the leader's own visible excellence and drive, using that example to pull the team's performance upward, often under real time pressure.

**WHEN TO USE**

A highly competent, self-motivated team needs fast results. The leader has deep expertise in the task itself and can credibly model the standard expected.

**STRENGTHS**

- Produces fast results with a highly skilled, self-driven team
- Sets a clear, visible standard of excellence
- Effective for short bursts under legitimate time pressure

**LIMITATIONS**

- Overused, it drives out team members who need more support or explanation
- Can create anxiety and burnout if sustained for long periods
- Struggles to scale — works one-to-one but rarely translates well across a large or diverse team

**SELF-ASSESSMENT PROMPTS**

**How often do you catch yourself thinking 'it would just be faster if I did this myself'? What does that habit cost your team's development?**

**When did you last sustain a fast pace for so long that your team's energy — or your own — visibly dropped?**

## LEADERSHIP STYLE

## Commanding

*"Do what I tell you."*

The commanding leader gives direct instructions and expects immediate compliance, without discussion. It is the most directive of the six styles, deliberately removing ambiguity and debate in situations where speed and clarity of command outweigh the value of consultation.

**WHEN TO USE**

A genuine crisis requires immediate, unambiguous action. Safety is at risk. A turnaround situation demands a fast, decisive break from a failing pattern.

**STRENGTHS**

- Removes ambiguity instantly — everyone knows exactly what to do
- Effective in genuine emergencies where debate would cost time or safety
- Can break a team out of a failing pattern that consensus-building has failed to shift

**LIMITATIONS**

- Damages morale and initiative when used outside genuine emergencies
- Suppresses the very information a leader most needs from experienced team members
- The most negatively correlated style with long-term engagement and trust of the six

**SELF-ASSESSMENT PROMPTS**

**Think of the last time you gave a direct instruction without explanation. Was it genuinely urgent, or was it simply the fastest option for you?**

**How would your team describe your default style if this one is the one they encounter most often?**

## Reading Your Pattern

Once you have worked through all six sets of prompts, look for a pattern rather than a single answer. Most leaders have one or two defaults they reach for automatically, and one or two they rarely use even when the situation calls for them.

| If your defaults are...                                         | Consider this                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Visionary / Coaching / Affiliative / Democratic dominant</b> | Your default leans participative and developmental. Watch for moments — genuine crises, urgent safety issues — where a more directive style is actually what the situation calls for.                                                               |
| <b>Pacesetting / Commanding dominant</b>                        | Your default leans directive and standard-setting. Watch for team members who are disengaging quietly rather than telling you they need a different approach — pacesetting and commanding are the two styles most likely to suppress that feedback. |
| <b>No clear dominant style</b>                                  | You may already be flexing naturally across styles. Confirm this by asking a trusted colleague which style they see you use most under pressure — self-perception and how you show up under stress often differ.                                    |

### THE REAL SKILL

Style flexibility — not any single style — is what research consistently links to the strongest team climate and performance. The goal of this guide is not to find your "best" style. It is to notice which styles you already reach for, and to deliberately practise the ones you do not.